Project Overview
In this project, we investigate how partisans respond to high-profile political errors and scandals by elite politicians. In particular, we investigate how co-partisan citizens react to these errors. Do they update their evaluations of the embattled elites, as a rational choice perspective might suggest? Or do they instead continue to support these elites at consistent rates, using motivated reasoning and cognitive consistency processes as a social psychological perspective might suggest? Finally, does the type of error or scandal matter? (I.e., is there an "affective tipping point"?) These questions are important in determining how citizens judge those who govern them, thus providing insight into the degree of democratic accountability in our democracy.

The Data
We have large-scale, state-level approval data for US presidents, senators, and state governors from 2005-2011. We hope to *merge* these data with a database of political scandals over the same time period. With such a dataset, we can use *interrupted time series* and *interrupted control series* (using *matching* to pair scandal-beset politicians to comparable non-embattled politicians) to measure apparent effects of high-profile political errors on partisans' evaluations of elite politicians.

Our *unit of analysis* is the politician-office. This means that one politician may appear twice in the dataset. (Only a few do.) For example, Sam Brownback served as both a senator from Kansas and a governor from Kansas between 2005-2011.

Coding
The list of politician-offices being studied is in this spreadsheet, which is also where coding should happen:

https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1bnIiFnI53Yl8YglLsmGmaRsu7UpoCjlWq-OGxena2wY/edit#gid=0

For each politician in the dataset, please conduct a search for the politician being seriously accused of any notable political errors, gaffes, scandals, or snafus between 2005 and 2011. In the column labeled "Scandal type," use the following code to indicate such a situation:

- 1 - a scandal involving adultery or other non-criminal sexual behavior
- 2 - prostitution, public solicitation, or other "victimless" sexual crimes
- 3 - sexual harassment, sexual assault, or similar sexual crimes
- 4 - alcohol abuse or DUI
- 5 - illicit drugs
- 6 - corruption or malfeasance (misuse of office)
- 7 - racist speech or behavior
- 8 - other inflammatory statements
- 9 - gross incompetence

Again, look for accusations serious enough to end up in reputable media outlets. The accusations do not have to imply firm guilt (e.g., the Chris Christie bridge scandal would be classified as “6” even though nothing has been proven about his direct role) but they also should not be fringe/tabloid accusations (e.g., Barack Obama being born outside of the US).

In the column labeled “Date scandal broke,” find the date (as close as possible) when a major media outlet picked up the story. Input this data as YYYY-MM-DD.

If a politician has multiple instances of these types of situations, duplicate his/her line and put the code for the second/third/etc. situation in the second/third/etc. line, along with the breaking date for the second/third/etc. situation.

Finally, put a hyperlink for the news source in the “Source” column for each situation you record.

Potential Sources
A great starting place:
http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/List_of_federal_political_scandals_in_the_United_States
http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/List_of_state_and_local_political_scandals_in_the_United_States

The politicians’ Wikipedia entries are probably a great place to start as well. If something does not make it there, it likely did not draw the attention of large numbers of constituents.